Logline

When precocious sixteen-year-old Jem discovers she's pregnant in her tiny Australian country town, she convinces her best friend Harry to steal his mum's car and drive her to Sydney for an abortion, but the journey across a vast and unfamiliar landscape forces both of them to confront what they really feel, for themselves and for each other.

Synopsis

Precocious sixteen-year-old JEM is determined to escape her small Australian country town. The only daughter of CHRISTINE, a single mum who fell pregnant as a teen, Jem is terrified of repeating her mother's mistake. So, when she discovers she's pregnant, her world collapses.

Jem hatches a plan. She turns up on best friend HARRY's doorstep, convinces him to steal his mum's beat-up 2005 Toyota Tarago and drive her to Sydney for an abortion. They lie to their parents and hit the road, but the journey isn't easy. The Tarago is barely roadworthy, and they've been forced to bring Christine's beloved pet rabbit, who's sick and needs constant care.

Short on cash for the termination, Jem calls BOMBER, the boarding-school jock she had a summer fling with, and the baby's "oops" father. When sparks reignite between Jem and Bomer, Harry feels jealous, revealing feelings he's kept hidden. Bomer doesn't take Jem's news well, rejecting her.

After the Tarago breaks down for good, Jem and Harry torch it to cover their tracks. In the charged aftermath, they kiss, but instead of bringing them closer, it terrifies Jem. Overwhelmed, she pushes Harry away, convinced she's ruined everything.

When Christine discovers Jem has been lying, she travels to Sydney to find her. Jem faces her hardest choice: tell her mum the truth and ask for the help she desperately needs or face the abortion alone. Christine learns the truth. She affirms for Jem that her body autonomy is hers and her love is unconditional.

Artist Statement

My Path to *Bean*

I am a director with over twenty years of experience working across theatre, television, and short film. Bean will be my feature film debut.

My career has been shaped by a deep commitment to stories that centre women, that illuminate social concerns, and demand emotionally truthful performances. On stage, I have directed over thirty professional productions for Australia's leading companies, including Leah Purcell's *The Drover's Wife* at Belvoir St Theatre, which won the Helpmann Award for Best Direction and Best Production. This collaboration led Leah to invite me to complete a director's attachment on her feature film *The Drover's Wife: The Legend of Molly Johnson*, where I gained first-hand experience of the creative and logistical demands of feature filmmaking. A second attachment followed with director Michael Rymer (*Battlestar Galactica*) on acclaimed TV series *The Fires* for ABC, supported by Film Victoria.

For television, I have directed across drama, comedy, and children's programming for Stan, SBS, ABC, Network Seven, Nickelodeon, and BBC earning nominations for AACTA, LOGIE, and ADG Awards. My episodes of SBS's *Erotic Stories* drew critical praise for their tonal control, balancing emotional vulnerability with humour and sensuality, skills directly transferable to *Bean*.

When screenwriter Claire Phillips sent me her script, I instantly recognised a story I had been waiting for: a coming-of-age romantic comedy with genuine dramatic stakes, a distinctly Australian voice, and a young woman at its centre whose choices carry real consequence. Claire and I partnered with producer Miriam Stein (Tama Films), whose work on *Hey, Hey, It's Esther Blueburger* signalled a shared sensibility. We have since secured development funding from Screen NSW and Claire is completing a third-draft polish with the goal of attracting marquee talent and marketplace partners.

Creative Vision

Bean is a coming-of-age romantic comedy about big dreams, big choices, big distances, and tiny secrets. It follows Jem, a sixteen-year-old determined to escape her small country town, who discovers she is pregnant and convinces her best friend Harry to drive her to Sydney for an abortion. Jem sets in motion a road trip that will test their friendship, ignite an unexpected romance, and force them both to grow up fast.

In classic Australian road-movie tradition, the vast landscape will be a character in the film. I will create a dynamic interplay between vehicle and camera: driving montages that celebrate the thrill of the open road, wide shots that capture the theme of escape, and an evolving visual palette from dry, brittle scrubland to coast and city that mirrors Jem and Harry's transformation. Films like *Little*

Miss Sunshine, *Obvious Child*, and *Ladybird* are touchstones: stories that marry scale with intimacy, and comedy with genuine emotional jeopardy.

However, *Bean* is ultimately a performance-driven film, and this is where my theatre background becomes my greatest asset. Twenty years of directing actors on stage have taught me how to build trust, excavate subtext, and help young performers access complex emotional terrain. When our scenes turn inward - Jem and Harry confronting problems beyond their lived experiences and navigating feelings they cannot name - I will shift to handheld camera with shallow focus, framing them in close, dirty shots that dissolve the exterior world and hold the audience inside the relationship and allow for intimacy with our heroes. My goal with this film is for it to feel both visually bold and deeply human.

Themes & Relevance

Through *Bean*, I want to destigmatise abortion and advance the conversation about reproductive access, particularly for young, rural people. Although abortion is legal in Australia, access remains starkly unequal: geographical distance, cost, and doctors' right to conscientious objection create barriers that disproportionately affect regional communities. The overturning of Roe v. Wade in the US has intensified global scrutiny of reproductive rights, making *Bean*'s subject matter urgent and resonant far beyond Australia.

Yet, *Bean* will not be a polemic. Its power lies in its warmth, humour, and emotional honesty. I want the audience to fall in love with Jem and Harry, to feel the stakes of their choices not as political abstractions but as a lived, visceral experience. I want young viewers to see their own struggles with identity, pressure, and the terror of asking for help reflected on screen. Stories like *Bean* are vital in encouraging open conversations about the complexities of adolescence, reducing stigma, and empowering a generation to face their challenges with courage and authenticity.

Why TIFF Directors' Lab

Bean is at a pivotal stage: development funding has been secured, the script is evolving into a third draft polish, and a strong creative team is in place. What we need now is the marketplace expertise to take it from development into production. TIFF Directors' Lab's focus on market readiness, combined with mentorship from directors who have navigated their own debuts, is precisely the catalyst this project needs. The opportunity to refine my pitch, connect with international distributors and financiers, and learn from the industry's best would be transformative for both *Bean* and my career as a first-time feature director.

LETICIA CÁCERES

Director

Cameron's Management · Joel Pettersson,
joel.pettersson@cameronsmanagement.com.au · www.leticiacaceres.com

PROFILE

Award-winning Australian director for screen and stage with over 20 years of experience. Television credits spanning drama, comedy, and children's programming for Stan, Network Seven, SBS, ABC, Nickelodeon, and BBC. Short films screened and awarded at international festivals including MIFF, London, Wellington, and Vancouver. Winner of multiple Helpmann, Green Room, and Sydney Theatre Awards. Nominated for AACTA, LOGIE, and ADG Awards. Over 30 professional stage productions for Australia's leading theatre companies.

PROFESSIONAL POSITIONS

Associate Director

Melbourne Theatre Company · 2012 to 2015

Directed mainstage and education productions. Implemented MTC's Women Directors Program. Curated education season and developed pathways for emerging artists.

Artistic Director

Tantrum Theatre, Newcastle · 2006 to 2008

Artistic programming, directing, strategic planning. National touring and community engagement.

Associate & Intern Director

Queensland Theatre Company · 2003 to 2005

Mainstage and education directing. New writing development and regional programmes.

Co-Founder & Co-Director

Real TV, Melbourne · 2000 to 2020

Independent production company. Nationally and internationally touring productions.

EDUCATION

Foundations in Film & Television

VCA, University of Melbourne · 2017

Master of Fine Arts, Drama Direction

VCA, University of Melbourne · 2014

Bachelor of Arts, Drama, Honours

Queensland University of Technology · 1999

GRANTS & FELLOWSHIPS

- Screen Australia, Developing the Developer · 2018
- Screen Australia, Gender Matters / Brilliant Careers · 2017
- British Council, Realise Your Dream Award · 2008
- Brisbane Lord Mayor's Fellowship for the Arts · 2005

FILMOGRAPHY

TELEVISION

RFDS, Season 3 · 2024

Director, Eps 5 & 6 · Endemol Shine · Network Seven

Rock Island Mysteries, S3 · 2024

Director, Eps 9, 11, 14, 16, 18 · Fremantle · Ch 10, Nickelodeon

Spooky Files, Season 2 · 2024

Set-Up Director, Eps 1, 3, 4 · TAP, Megaboom · ABC, BBC

- **Nom., Best Children's Program** · AACTA, 2025

Erotic Stories · 2023

Director, Eps 1, 4, 6, 8 · Lingo Pictures · SBS

- **Nom., Best Direction Drama Series** · ADG, 2024
- **Nom., Most Outstanding Drama** · LOGIE, 2023
- **Nom., Best Drama Series** · AACTA, 2023

Spooky Files, Season 1 · 2023

Director, Eps 6, 7 · TAP, Megaboom · ABC

- **Nom., Best Drama Series** · AACTA, 2024

Bump, Seasons 1 & 2 · 2021 to 2022

Director, Eps 8, 9, 10 per season · Roadshow Rough Diamond · Stan

Intl: BBC One, CW Network, HBO Max LatAm, Sky NZ, CBC Gem

- **Nom., Most Outstanding Drama** · LOGIE, 2022
- **Nom., Best Drama Series** · AACTA, 2021 & 2022

The Fires · 2021

Director's Attachment, Dir. Michael Rymer · TAP · ABC

FILM

Weight Limit · 2026

Writer, Director · Short Film · 13 min · Family Drama

English / Spanish / Japanese

The Drover's Wife: The Legend of Molly Johnson · 2021

Director's Attachment, Dir. Leah Purcell · Feature · Bunya Productions

The True History of Billie The Kid · 2019

Director, Co-Producer · Short Film · 8 min

MIFF · Wollongong FF · Peninsula FF · Wellington Independent FF · Worldwide Women in Film, AZ · Vancouver Intl Women in Film

- **Winner, Best Drama** · Wellington Independent FF, 2019
- **Winner, Best Short Film** · Peninsula FF, 2019
- **Winner, Best Short Film** · Wollongong FF, 2018
- **Winner, Best Student Film** · London Independent Film Awards, 2018

Wild · 2017

Writer, Director, Producer · Short Film · 2 min

Melbourne Women in Film Fest · Setting Sun FF · Sanctuary Cove FF

- **Winner, Gold Lion First Time Director** · London Film Awards, 2018
- **Winner, Next Gen Best Student Film** · Melbourne Women in Film, 2018

Going Down · 2020

Director · Webseries Pilot · Dramedy

SELECTED THEATRE · 2002 TO 2022

Director of 30+ professional productions. Selected credits:

Tell Me I'm Here · 2022
Director · Belvoir St Theatre

The Mares · 2019
by Kate Mulvany · Director · Tasmanian Theatre Company

- ✦ **Winner, Outstanding Direction** · Tasmanian Theatre Awards, 2020
- ✦ **Winner, Outstanding Production** · Tasmanian Theatre Awards, 2020

Barbara and the Camp Dogs · 2018
by Ursula Yovich & Alana Valentine · Director · Belvoir St Theatre

- ✦ **Winner, Best Musical** · Helpmann Awards, 2019

Random · 2018
by debbie tucker green · Director · Belvoir St Theatre

- ○ **Nom., Best Director** · Sydney Theatre Awards, 2019

Going Down · 2018
by Michelle Lee · Director · Malthouse Theatre / STC

- ○ **Nom., Best Director** · Green Room Awards, 2018

The House of Bernarda Alba · 2018
by Patricia Cornelius, after Lorca · Director · MTC

The Drover's Wife · 2016
by Leah Purcell · Director · Belvoir St Theatre

- ✦ **Winner, Best Direction** · Helpmann Awards, 2017
- ✦ **Winner, Best Production** · Helpmann Awards, 2017
- ✦ **Winner, Best Direction** · Sydney Theatre Awards, 2017
- ✦ **Winner, Best Production** · Sydney Theatre Awards, 2017

Birdland · 2015
by Simon Stephens · Director · MTC

- ✦ **Winner, Best Direction** · Green Room Awards, 2016

Mortido · 2015
by Angela Betzien · Director · Belvoir Theatre / STCSA

Death and the Maiden · 2015
by Ariel Dorfman · Director · MTC / STC

Hoods · 2006 to 2011
by Angela Betzien · Director · National & International Tours
Sydney Opera House · Kennedy Centre, Washington DC · Cortile Theatre, Italy · Dschungel Wien, Austria

- ✦ **Winner, Best Independent Production** · Matilda Awards, 2009
- ○ **Nom., Best Children's Theatre** · Helpmann Awards, 2007

Additional credits include productions for Melbourne Theatre Company, Sydney Theatre Company, Queensland Theatre Company, and State Theatre Company of South Australia, 2002 to 2014.